

TOPIC 05

Making the case

Present the business case to the board — and win the decision

From the written case to the room

a great case still has to be sold

- The written case is done (Topics 2–4) — this Topic is about communicating and defending it.
- Three moves: prepare & rehearse → deliver → handle the room.
- This is the presentation event — an observed assessment: how you present is assessed, not just what you built.

01

SECTION

Prepare & rehearse

from document to pitch

The pitch is a distillation, not a read-through

- A board deck isn't your business case with slide borders — the board already read the document.
- The deck carries the spine — the ask, the money, the risk, the plan; you fill the rest verbally.
- 8–10 slides, one section each, with speaker notes — on the YAT Board Presentation Deck template.

The board arc

order it the way a board decides

- Agenda → strategic context → current state → the gap → options → recommendation
- cost summary → benefits → risks → implementation plan → the decision → Q&A
- One section per slide: headline + a few points. The recommendation and the plan get the airtime.

What makes the cut

- KEEP — the ask · the cost comparison · key risks + mitigations · the plan · the strategic fit.
- CUT — line-item detail · method explanations · anything that lives in the appendices.
- If a slide doesn't help the decision, it's a handout — not a pitch slide.

Rehearse — this is where pitches are won

- Preparation isn't done when the deck is built. Rehearse:
 - run it aloud — walk the board through each slide, don't read it
 - time it (target 10–15 min); if you run long, cut
 - anticipate the board's questions and prepare your answers
 - practise stating the ask and asking for sign-off — the bit most often fumbled
- A rehearsed pitch sounds confident; an unrehearsed one reads off the slides.

ACTIVITY

Build & rehearse your board deck

- Build an 8–10 slide board deck for your practice Business Case (Accounting System / Ledgerline) on the YAT Board Presentation Deck template, with speaker notes.
- Then rehearse it:
 - run it aloud and time it (target 10–15 min)
 - in your notes, write the three questions you'd least like to be asked – and your answers
- Lead with the section spine; slides = headline + a few points; end on the decision.
- ⚠ Rehearsal isn't optional – a pitch you haven't said aloud isn't ready.



~30 min build + rehearse, then we present

Key takeaways

Section 1 · Prepare & rehearse

The deck is a distillation — the spine, not the whole document.

Board arc: context → gap → options → recommendation → cost/risk → plan → the ask.

Preparation includes rehearsal: run it aloud, time it, prepare for the questions.

02

SECTION

Deliver the case

present to the board

Lead with the ask

- A board listens better when it knows what you want.
- Open by naming the decision you're seeking — then walk them through the case that justifies it.
- Don't hide the ask on the last slide.

Walk the board through it

- Report the situation and the gap.
- Walk through how you evaluated the options — the CBA + risk.
- Put the action plan — explicitly seeking the board's feedback and approval.
- You're reporting to a superior and asking for a decision, not lecturing.

Speak the board's language

- The board is not technical.
- Plain English; translate each technical term as you use it – “RDS: a managed database the vendor runs for us”.
- Pitch ideas in business terms – cost, risk, availability, continuity.
- Jargon loses the room.

ACTIVITY

Deliver your pitch

- Present your board deck to a mock board (peers + trainer as Sam Walker / Pat Lin), 10–15 minutes.
- Remember to:
 - open with the ask
 - walk context → gap → options → recommendation → cost/risk → plan
 - translate technical terms as you go; eyes on the room, not the slides
- ⚠ You're seeking a decision — present to persuade, not to inform.



10–15 min each, then feedback

Key takeaways

Section 2 · Deliver the case

Lead with the ask, then justify it.

Report → evaluate → put the plan and seek approval.

Plain English, technical terms translated, pitched to a non-technical board.

03

SECTION

Handle the room

Q&A, feedback & sign-off

Q&A is assessed

- The board's questions aren't a formality — they probe whether you understand your own analysis and the principles behind it.
- Defend your case from your evidence; don't bluff.

Listen, then answer

- Let the question land; clarify if unsure — “Do you mean cost or risk?”
- Answer directly, pointing to your evidence (your CBA, your risk register).
- Check it landed before moving on.
- A crisp “good question — here's the data” beats a long ramble.

Be ready for these

the dimensions the board probes

- Cost assumptions — what if pricing changes?
- Risk — the single biggest reason to say no?
- Prioritisation — which change carries the most risk?
- Strategic fit — what if YAT opens a second campus in Year 3?
- Service models & standards — why IaaS/PaaS here? which standards informed it?
- These come from your own Topics 1–4 work — defend, don't re-derive.

Seek feedback & get sign-off

- Explicitly seek and respond to the board's feedback — confirm you've understood it.
- Capture the feedback in the Feedback Record.
- Obtain the board's sign-off on the action plan.
- The decision is the point of the whole exercise — ask for it.

ACTIVITY

Run the Q&A, feedback & sign-off

- After each pitch, the mock board asks 3–5 questions, gives feedback, and signs off.
 - Presenter: clarify → answer from your evidence → seek/respond to feedback → capture it → get the sign-off.
 - Board: probe across the dimensions above.
- ⚠ Always close by asking for the decision.



~5 min each, then debrief

Key takeaways

Section 3 · Handle the room

Q&A tests your grasp of your own case — defend it from your evidence.

Listen, clarify, answer directly, check it landed.

Seek and respond to feedback, capture it, and obtain sign-off — always ask for the decision.

From the practice room to the real thing

You can now build a board deck, deliver it, and handle the room – the whole communication skill.

That completes the case for the migration: analyse it, plan it, and sell it.

You practised on the Accounting System; next you do it for real.

Next: produce and present your real Business Case for the YAT LMS migration.